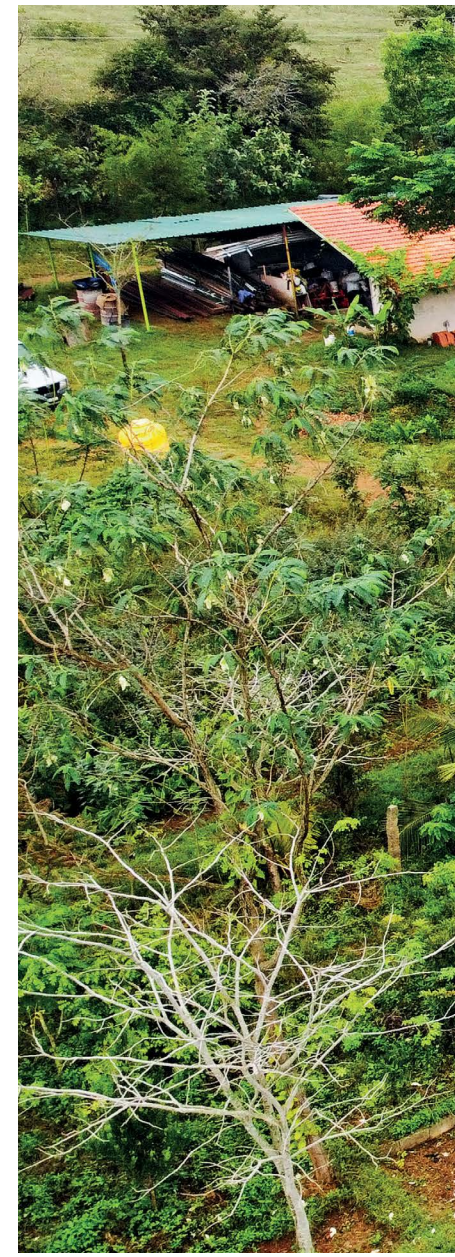
BACK TO NATURE

Moved by the environmental degradation around them, a growing tribe of professionals is leaving behind the urban life and seeking purpose in this form of farming in the hinterlands of India

By Sonal Khetarpal



ON THE OUTSKIRTS OF PANCHKULA DISTRICT in Haryana lies the sprawling 12-acre Aanandaa Permaculture Farm, built as a testament to the harmony between humans, plants and animals. Unlike conventional farms with their rows of monoculture crops, Aanandaa resembles a lush forest where more than 6,000 trees intermingle with a diverse array of plants, creepers and shrubs in seemingly chaotic fashion. Co-founded by Manisha Lath Gupta, former marketing head of Uber India, and her husband, Agam Gupta, the farm follows the principles of permaculture, a model of agriculture that leverages the complementary qualities of plants, trees and animals to create a self-sustaining and regenerative 'food forest'.

For Manisha, the motivation to establish Aanandaa stemmed from a deep concern over the devastating effects of modern agriculture on the environment—a long list that includes deforestation and soil degradation, tracing a line all the way up to climate change. "The idea is to go back to a horticultural society where food is foraged instead of grown," she says. On her transition from the corporate boardroom, Gupta says, "We often think about financial security, but in a world witnessing an alarming rise in freak weather incidents, it's time to prioritise green security for our children's future."

RISING INTEREST

The word permaculture was coined by Australian environmentalists Bill Mollison and David Holmgren in 1978. However, it was in July 1987 that permaculture first made its presence felt in India, after the founders taught a course in the country. Dr Narsanna Koppula, who was then working with an NGO to improve farmers' lives, attended a lecture, which changed him forever. "India had a rich history of permaculture. Our ancient text, *Vrikshayurveda*, focuses on the science of plant life. It's just that, over time, with the advent of the Green Revolution, we forgot those traditional practices." The realisation prompted him to start Aranya Agricultural Alternatives in Hyderabad.

After a decade of conducting permaculture design courses and establishing his own farm, Koppula organised a conference, 'National Permaculture Convergence', in Chennai in 2016. The event was attended by some 1,100 sustainability enthusiasts. Encouraged by the response, he expanded the scope of the event to include international participants the following year; this attracted delegates from 72 countries.

Within two years, permaculture became a byword among nature-lovers in